

Lesson 4: Personal Brand: What's Yours?

Morgan Vance

The King, The Iron Lady, The People's Princess, The Notorious B.I.G., The Baltimore Bullet, The Queen of Country Music. Chances are, each of these statements brought a unique individual to mind, and these names were given for a reason: Elvis Presley, Margaret Thatcher, Princess Diana, Christopher Wallace, Michael Phelps, and Dolly Parton.

These people were each known for a certain set of attributes, including having a very, very strong personal brand. You may not be a celebrity, pop star, or talk show host, but you yourself do have a personal brand. We all do. And while we can't control a lot of the things that go on around us, no one can control your personal brand but you. You are responsible for the attitude, image, and skill set that comes to mind when people think of you.

Have you ever thought about it before? Maybe, maybe not, but it's real, whether we choose to think about it or not. So what do you want people to think about when your name comes to mind? What do they currently think of?

When I was growing up, I knew I wanted to be a leader and make a difference in my community, but I also knew I wanted to be a mom. Growing up in Knoxville, I received the benefit of watching strong female leaders like Pat build their personal brands. She was a leader both on and off the court and showed me that you could be successful in both your professional and personal life.

I will never forget watching her come to high school basketball games and sit silently on the front row, rooting on her son. She didn't draw attention to herself. She didn't let her professional work come into her personal time. She was there to be a mom.

The truth is, personal brand matters and you can shape yours. Let's start by defining what a personal brand is. Your personal brand is a unique combination of your skills, experiences, values, and personality that sets you apart from others. It's your identity, how you present yourself to the world, both online and offline.

Whether it's through your interactions with colleagues, social media, or the skills you provide as part of your daily routine, your personal brand is always on display. Personal brand is the key to differentiating yourself from others with similar skills or qualifications. By showcasing your unique strengths, passions, and values, you position yourself as a distinct and memorable individual.

An authentic personal brand is one that aligns with your true self. Trying to be someone you're not can be exhausting and unsustainable in the long run. At its core, a positive personal brand is

built on attitude and trustworthiness. When you consistently deliver on your promises and showcase your expertise, you establish credibility in your field.

A strong personal brand can leave a lasting positive impression, opening doors to new opportunities. So take a minute and think about where you are with your personal brand. What things do you like? What don't you like? And this lesson will explore the concept of personal brands some more, as well as exercises you can do to uncover yours.